



e-commerce site builders, such as Shopify or Wix, offer ready-made website templates onto which you simply drag and drop your content. They also provide secure payment systems, customer data protection, and elements such as shopping carts, search bars, wishlist functions, and review options.

Alternatively, you can sell your products on large online marketplaces, such as Amazon, eBay, Etsy, or Facebook Marketplace, which also have the necessary infrastructure. Whichever option you choose, your customers will buy your products only if they like what they see and read. Be sure to describe them clearly and accurately and include attractive, but honest, images.

SEARCH ENGINE OPTIMIZATION (SEO)

If you are selling on your own website, rather than an online marketplace, it will be up to you to make your site visible to potential customers. Most people search the internet using a search engine, such as Google, which creates a list of sites related to your search term. As most users only view the first few options listed, website owners compete to be as close to the top of these lists as possible. There are various ways you can optimise your website for search engines and improve your ranking (pp.118–119).

E-commerce site builders



These website builders specialize in e-commerce and offer software services for free or by subscription.

You can choose from a template and fill in information fields to create a site and use the shopping cart systems to sell, ship, and manage your products.

PROS

- › **Easy to set up**, requiring little technical knowledge and no ongoing maintenance
- › **Commonly multilingual**, so more likely to appeal to a global audience
- › **Provides secure** payment and data systems, and other e-commerce tools, with some guarantees and insurance

CONS

- › **Fees are payable**, either as a subscription or as commission charged on sales—typically 2–5 percent or more
- › **Customer service terms** and conditions are set by the site builder, with no flexibility
- › **Site structure** is fixed by the site builder, which might not be optimized for search engines
- › **Design is limited** to the site's available templates



Online marketplaces



These sites are like huge, online supermarkets, where thousands of products are listed internationally.

To sell on these sites, you just need to create an account, choose a selling plan (in some cases), and then list your items.

PROS

- › **No need to create** or market a website
- › **Easier to market** your product
- › **Massive marketplace** with international reach
- › **Multilingual** and can deal with different currencies
- › **E-commerce tools** are all supplied

CONS

- › **Thousands of sellers** make it hard to stand out
- › **Referral fees** (the commission the sites take when items are sold) can be high—up to 45 percent depending on the site and product sold
- › **Site structure and selling terms** are fixed and may not suit your business

